

Breaking POINT

As politicians seek to build their capital over terror, the people react with anger and disgust. Heads roll, but it's far too little.

By Priya Sahgal

The target may have been Mumbai's symbolism and stature but the collateral damage from the terror strike in Mumbai has hit India's political class the hardest. At no other time in history have Indian politicians been so despised and exposed to public pressure and anger. Barely had the smoke cleared from the targets of the terror attack that the simmering volcano of resentment against politicians exploded. It wasn't just victims and relatives, the outpouring against politicians spanned the nation. Indeed, so powerful and spontaneous was its scope and spread that parties and leaders entered public spaces at their own peril. Gujarat Chief Minister Narendra Modi, who has the image of a politician who is tough on terror, arrived in Mumbai in the middle of the operation only to hastily backpedal in embarrassment when the widow of the just-slain head of Maharashtra's Anti-Terrorism Squad Hemant Karkare spurned his offer of monetary compensation.

The need of the hour is political consensus on a strong anti-terror law and to set up a mechanism to fight terror both at the state and Central levels. Prime Minister Manmohan Singh needs to call an all-party meeting and discuss ways to tackle terrorism. Instead, the politicians have only fuelled public fury by exposing their insensitivity and crass misinterpretation of the public mood.



From BJP Vice-President Mukhtar Abbas Naqvi who expressing self-righteous anger against "some women wearing lipstick and powder, and men in suits and ties taking to the streets and spreading distrust against politicians..." to an even worse display of arrogance and tactlessness by Kerala Chief Minister V.S. Achuthanandan and his "even a dog" insult to slain NSG commando Major Sandeep Unnikrishnan's family, the stock of politicians has never sunk lower.

The biggest fallout, inevitably, was on Maharashtra's ruling coalition where heads had to roll but not before the sacrificial lambs contributed to the litany of gaffes. First, it was state deputy chief minister NCP's R.R. Patil, who made a laughing stock of himself by describing the terror attacks as "a small thing that happens in a big city". Even